Library of India (MCLI), a 100-year effort to translate and publish ancient Indian classics for the world in a bid to save and celebrate them, we are now beginning to ask whether, in addition to translations, we should be attempting to store the 'essence' of classical languages in LLMs by having them learn from our translated texts. Can LLMs aid in preserving culture, literature and language forever? India will certainly benefit from such advances. Hence, these modern AI algorithms are not just redefining our relationship with words; they are reshaping the very fabric of communication and memory.

Consider the implications for white-collar professions, where words are the primary tools—consultants, programmers, accountants, managers, editors, journalists, legal analysts, among others. Here, AI can augment human effort, streamlining tasks, and enhance creativity. The current revolution in AI will reshape our notion of how work can and ought to be done. These new models now have the power to decipher how teams in companies work, what bottlenecks ail them every day and what kinds of solutions can help them succeed in meeting their goals. For the past 50 years, this sort of knowledge and work was purely in the bastion of hired consultants. But the latest AI models can now do what many consultants do, and perhaps even more. Hence, we are not just talking about incremental changes; we are witnessing a paradigm shift in how we will work and think.

Why has this current version of the AI revolution caught the public imagination? Most of us availing ourselves of almost any service via the Internet have likely benefited from AI models for the past two decades. But they have all been hidden in the back end, tucked away deep in the code on servers, and employed in areas such as fraud detection in credit cards and anomaly detection in traffic patterns on the Internet, among other uses. Hence, end consumers have had little knowledge of the existence of AI or what it is doing for them. What is different this time around is that these recent advances in AI are taking place on the 'front end', i.e., redefining how humans and machines interact with each other. They offer a powerful natural language interface for humans and machines to communicate with each other, freeing humans from the burden of having to learn technical ways of interacting with a machine. Natural expressions and language, much like how we communicate with other humans, can now become the lingua franca for how we communicate with machines. Hence, this will change the experience for anybody interacting with a computer, phone or any computing device anywhere.

But, as with all great advancements, there's a caveat. These models are only as good as the data they are fed. 'Garbage in, garbage out', as the saying goes. In most cases, they don't yet conjure knowledge from thin air, but build upon the information we provide. This limitation is a reminder of the symbiotic relationship between human intelligence and artificial intelligence.

TAKEAWAYS

- Transformers, a groundbreaking class of AI algorithms, have empowered machines to not just consume but understand and generate text in a way that simulates human thought
- The current revolution in AI will reshape our notion of how work can and ought to be done
- But these models are only as good as the data they are fed

The future holds immense potential, especially as people liken the advent of AI to the transformative era of the Internet's birth. However, I believe AI's impact extends far beyond. While the Internet has served as a vast repository of information, it hasn't inherently provided the means to interpret this information meaningfully. AI models step in to bridge this gap, analysing and synthesising the vast data troves to extract and construct knowledge. In essence, where the Internet has been humanity's data archive, AI is becoming our means to convert that data into a comprehensive knowledge base.

This shift promises that no sector, from industries to individual jobs, will remain unchanged by AI's integration. The educational landscape is poised for a revolutionary change. More profoundly, we stand at an intellectual and philosophical juncture, reflecting on the essence of cognition, intelligence, and thought itself, and how AI might mirror or even expand these human faculties. The journey ahead is not just about technological advancement but a deeper understanding and enhancement of human capability. ■

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